

Frequently Asked Questions

The following are questions commonly asked by judges coming to ISEF. This document is only a quick reference. Fuller answers to these and many other questions will appear in documents that posted to various sections of the ISEF *Judge Information Board*. Periodic emails will announce when we post these documents. If you do not find an answer to your question, please contact your category co-chairs, the Chair of Judging, or the Society for Science at judging@societyforscience.org. FYI, parking is the #1 question judges ask.

FAQ: Logistics

Where do I park?

ISEF will provide parking for judges who drive to the Convention Center. You will receive detailed instructions two weeks before the Fair. ISEF will also post these instructions to the Judge Information Board in document *A: Parking* within Section III – *Operational Details*.

Where do I check-in?

Registration for everyone (students, judges, volunteers) will be in the Kay Bailey Hutchison Convention Center. See document *B: Where Do I Go?* in Section III – *Operational Details*.

When do I check-in?

Registration for judges is on Tuesday, May 16, 2023, but *only* from 12:00 noon until 5:00 pm.

How long do I need to be at the Convention Center?

On Tuesday, you are only *required* to register. However, since you are already in the building, we strongly recommend that you visit the project displays, especially those of the projects you are scheduled to interview. The building will stay open for this purpose until 9:00 pm.

On Wednesday, for purposes of meeting with your fellow judges, interviewing students, and determining awards, you must be present for the entire day from 8:00 am until early evening when you will finish award decisions.

Are meals provided?

Yes. ISEF will provide dinner on Tuesday, as well as breakfast, lunch, and dinner on Wednesday in the area of the judge meeting rooms.

Where can I place personal items during judging?

A secured Coat Check room will be available for all personal items. In addition, all judge caucus rooms are isolated in a secure area of the Convention Center.

FAQ: Interviewing Students

Can I introduce myself to the students?

Yes. The students have your name on their schedule, so they already know yours. Everyone is required to have a valid nametag simply to be in the display area. Your nametag may also identify your work/academic affiliation.

Should I judge a project if I do not have much expertise in the technology or topic?

Yes. Focus your interview on other aspects of the project because other judges who do have expertise in the area will address the issues you cannot. For a fuller discussion, see Section II, Document *D: How to Interview*.

Should I judge a project that does not belong in my category?

Yes. You are judging the quality of science or engineering produced by the student, not whether the student's choice of category agrees with yours. See Section II, Document *I: Judging Policy on Category Selection*.

How can I start the interview?

From your initial review of the project, you should have some basic questions prepared to start the interview. For more suggestions, see Section II, Document *D: How to Interview*.

What should I do if the student can't answer my questions?

Move on to other questions. Again, see Section II, Document *D: How to Interview*.

How do I interview the student when there is an interpreter present?

Face the student and speak to him/her, not the interpreter. More details are provided in the document in Section II, Document *E: Interviewing Students Who Don't Speak English*.

What should I expect when the project is a team project?

All students should have a basic knowledge of the entire project, and each should demonstrate significant contributions. Teams at ISEF do not have a designated "Spokesperson."

Should I point out errors or potential problems with a student's project?

No. Doing so would affect subsequent judge interviews. Again, see Section II, Document *D: How to Interview*.

What do I do if I think that there is a problem with the research (*e.g., plagiarism, not the student's own work, etc.*)?

You should discover this problem from your preview of the project in the days leading up to the fair, and always before any interviews. If this is the case, speak to your co-chair. ISEF has a mechanism in place to consider this issue. It is not for you to resolve.

However, if you do not discover this problem until your interview with the student, it is too late to do anything about it. DO NOT accuse the student of improper behavior. Just as importantly, DO NOT raise the issue in the caucus because any accusation would unfairly taint the project with insufficient time to investigate the issue fairly. See Section II, Document *G: Student Scientific Misconduct*.

Can I contact the student if we share an area of interest and I would like to provide assistance, or if I wish to recruit the student to my research group or university?

Not directly. Judges wishing to help or provide feedback to a finalist must go through the Society for Science to make this contact. Email judging@societyforscience.org to initiate the process of establishing a connection.

Can I interview a student a second time before I enter their score?

No.

How can I differentiate between the student's work and that of a mentor?

ISEF requires any student working in a Regulated Research Institutional Setting have their research advisor complete ISEF Form 1C which they must post at the project display. This will provide some clues, but the best way is simply to ask the student questions to clarify what they know about the operational details of their own work. Again, see Section II, Document *D: How to Interview*.

FAQ: Judging and Scoring

How do I score projects?

There is a standardized scoring rubric provided in the document in Section III – *ISEF Judging Criteria*, but you can use whatever scoring system is comfortable for you. ISEF will transform your scores into a form enabling a fair comparison with all judge scores. See Section III, Document *H: What Every Judge Needs to Know about Scoring Projects*.

What should I do if two projects are basically equivalent?

While it is *permissible* to give the same score to different projects, as a rule you should try your best not to do so because the result will often not be what you intended. See Section III, Document *H: What Every Judge Needs to Know about Scoring Projects*.

Which criteria, science or engineering, should I use if my category contains both types of projects?

Use the criteria that are most appropriate to evaluate each project. See Section II, Document *F: ISEF Judging Criteria*.

How do I evaluate individual projects relative to team projects?

Evaluate projects only on the quality of the research. However, all team members should demonstrate significant contributions. In view of increased available resources, it is fair to expect more from a project developed by more students. See Section II, Document *D: How to Interview*.

How do I evaluate home vs. school vs. institutional projects?

You are judging the quality of what the student actually accomplished, not whether the work is publishable in scientific journals. Students who were given a project in, and supported by, a professional research lab may or may not have accomplished more than students working on their own without any external support. You can only find out by talking with the student. See the related FAQ above as well as Section II, Document *D: How to Interview*.

FAQ: Caucusing

Should I vote on projects during caucusing if I did not interview those students?

Yes. In fact, no judge will have interviewed more than a small fraction of the projects in the category. Consequently, all judges must necessarily rely on the results of other judges scoring projects along with their oral reports during the caucus.

Do I have to vote?

No. Abstentions are allowed and do not count for or against any proposition.

Can Co-chairs vote?

No. Co-chairs do not vote, nor will they express an opinion on any project. During the caucus, co-chairs will only direct discussion and provide information.